

IS THE IMPOSSIBLE POSSIBLE?

The mission, which we chose to accept, is to analyse the technology showcased in *Mission Impossible IV* and see how it compares with current generation technology. Here are our findings. Warning: Spoilers ahead

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Most of you must have watched the latest *Mission Impossible* movie by now, either in theatres or by, ahem, other means. Being Digit readers, your eyes must have surely first fallen on the tech (shame on you if they didn't), ours did and we immediately fell into a deep discussion regarding it. Does this tech really exist? In fact, can it exist? Read on to find out.

Orders that self-destruct

Now this is interesting, a staple feature in all the *MIIV* movies so far. What we couldn't figure out was why it had to be so complicated? Think about it, would you ever want to be so close to an explosive device, something you know is going to blow up when the sound stops? A ticking time-bomb anyone? Of course, Ethan Hunt, who is a shrewd and cunning agent with nerves of steel, a heart of gold and pearly white teeth, wouldn't hesitate. But who would actually want to wear a pair of sunglasses when they know it's filled with explosives? We wouldn't, not voluntarily anyway.

For an agency which makes the impossible possible, making sure that the explosive only goes off at exactly the right

Sugarcoated instructions, anyone?

time is a walk in the park. For us mere mortals there's a simpler solution. Why not just inscribe the message on chocolate? Imagine the following scenario, agent goes to vending machine, taps in a long and complicated code. Out pops the chocolate, agent reads it, assimilates message and chocolate. Clean and simple. No mess, no hassles and the agent gets to eat delicious chocolate (it better be, he is risking his life for his country after all) in the bargain. It also won't draw as much attention as an exploding telephone.

We say

It seems to be nothing more than just a theatrical and overtly complicated way of doing a simple job. Guess the IMF is called the "Intelligent Mission force" for a reason!

Look, Spiderman!

You'll remember the scene where Ethan Hunt goes scrambling around the Burj Khalifa like a lizard on steroids, using nothing more than a pair of grippy shoes and some super-grippy gloves equipped with weird, glowing LEDs while emitting an electronic buzz.

Firstly, what's the point of stealth when you're wearing buzzing gloves which glow. Suction cups would have probably served better, especially on a glass surface. Secondly, was the Burj Khalifa empty that nobody noticed at least the silhouette of

Ethan Hunt as he flailed around on the outside of the window?

Incidentally, the gloves worn by Ethan Hunt actually exist. These gloves are better known as Gecko gloves, whose design is based on the feet of, well, geckos. Contrary to what you may expect, the gecko doesn't just specialise in licking its own eyeballs, its feet are masters of adhesion and can, in theory, cling to the outside of the International Space Station with as much ease with which it clings to glass on Earth. There's a force called the "Van Der Waal's force", which comes into play when two surfaces are in contact. This



A variety of hairy gecko feet

force is so weak that even the extremely weak electrostatic force of attraction between a charged glass rod and piece of paper is many hundreds of times stronger. Basically, the more the area in contact, the more the attractive force. That's not to say that you'll get stuck to your bed and find it difficult to get up (no, you can't attribute your inability to get off the bed